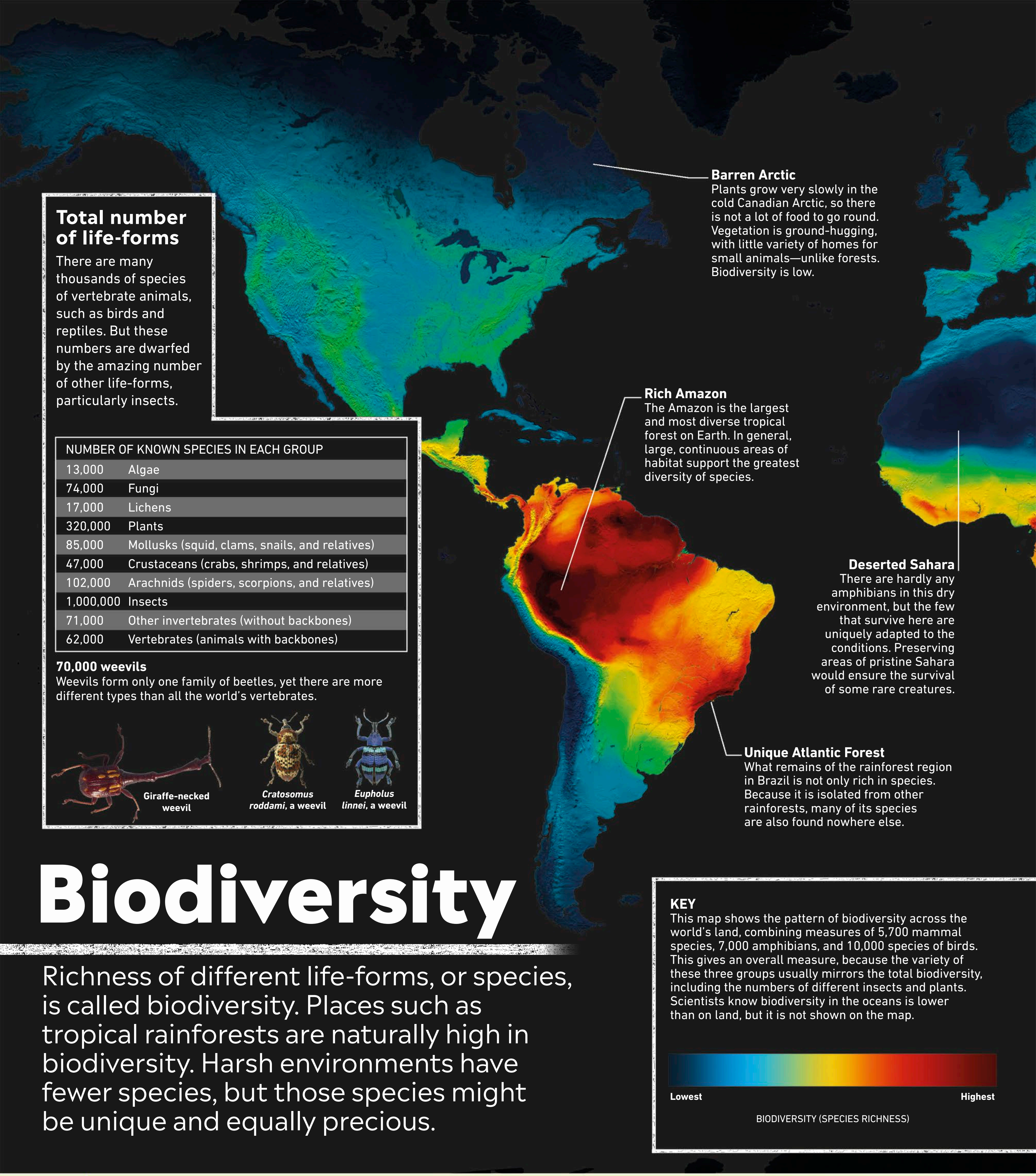
Biodiversity

Richness of different life-forms, or species, is called biodiversity. Places such as tropical rainforests are naturally high in biodiversity. Harsh environments have fewer species, but those species might be unique and equally precious.



Barren Arctic
Plants grow very slowly in the cold Canadian Arctic, so there is not a lot of food to go round. Vegetation is ground-hugging, with little variety of homes for small animals—unlike forests. Biodiversity is low.

Rich Amazon
The Amazon is the largest and most diverse tropical forest on Earth. In general, large, continuous areas of habitat support the greatest diversity of species.

Deserted Sahara
There are hardly any amphibians in this dry environment, but the few that survive here are uniquely adapted to the conditions. Preserving areas of pristine Sahara would ensure the survival of some rare creatures.

Unique Atlantic Forest
What remains of the rainforest region in Brazil is not only rich in species. Because it is isolated from other rainforests, many of its species are also found nowhere else.

Total number of life-forms

There are many thousands of species of vertebrate animals, such as birds and reptiles. But these numbers are dwarfed by the amazing number of other life-forms, particularly insects.

NUMBER OF KNOWN SPECIES IN EACH GROUP	
13,000	Algae
74,000	Fungi
17,000	Lichens
320,000	Plants
85,000	Mollusks (squid, clams, snails, and relatives)
47,000	Crustaceans (crabs, shrimps, and relatives)
102,000	Arachnids (spiders, scorpions, and relatives)
1,000,000	Insects
71,000	Other invertebrates (without backbones)
62,000	Vertebrates (animals with backbones)

70,000 weevils
Weevils form only one family of beetles, yet there are more different types than all the world's vertebrates.

Giraffe-necked weevil · ***Cratosomus roddami*, a weevil** · ***Eupholus linnei*, a weevil**

KEY
This map shows the pattern of biodiversity across the world's land, combining measures of 5,700 mammal species, 7,000 amphibians, and 10,000 species of birds. This gives an overall measure, because the variety of these three groups usually mirrors the total biodiversity, including the numbers of different insects and plants. Scientists know biodiversity in the oceans is lower than on land, but it is not shown on the map.

Lowest — Highest

BIODIVERSITY (SPECIES RICHNESS)

SCIENTISTS ESTIMATE THAT GLOBAL BIODIVERSITY HAS FALLEN TO 84.6